

FATHER SOLANUS, NOTEBOOK No. 2

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For Poor Souls - Nov. 3, 1916 - Rewritten

"(Bl. are the merciful; for they shall obtain mercy.)"
Matt. V-7Bl. is he that understandeth concerning the needy and the poor (Ps. XL-1)

Love never wearies hearing of the object of its affections. And we as children of the one Church that loves the Poor Souls in Purgatory and pleads for them as her most dear children, should never tire hearing of these same our suffering brothers and sisters. As members of the League we should never tire praying for them. True, it was only yesterday we heard a sermon in their behalf, but one sermon should satisfy the zeal of one one. We must foster devotion to the poor souls. We must show them compassion. We must exercise mercy toward them. Then only can it be said of us in the truest sense, "Bl. is he that understandeth concerning ---poor." For indeed of all our friends, Dr. Br., the souls in P. are the most N. & P. But---in order to do this properly, i.e. foster devotion to the poor souls - show them compassion and mercy, we must go into details especially in regards to their condition at once and their dispositions. For indeed this alone - their condition and their dispositions - if only understood is enough to move any one but a reprobate to earnest compassion. What then is their condition? What are their dispositions? The condition of the Souls in Purg. is one at once of unspeakable pain and of absolute helplessness. If it were possible for us to realize the awful terrors of the pains of hell then we might favor quite an accurate idea of what the poor souls in purgatory suffer: for spiritual writers agree that the fires of purgatory are quite the same, as long as they last, as the fires of hell itself. One difference there is, however, that makes a contrast indeed between the sufferings in the two places --Eternal despair on the one hand and on the other an assured certainty of ..and eternal glory with God. But what shall we say of the dispositions of the souls in Purg. What can we say, worthy of their real dignity - of their holiness. For they are saints indeed, every one of them - some of them just about to be crowned in Heaven. Their dispositions are entirely supernatural. Their humility is next to that of the angels of God. Their faith has become a realization not only of God's justice and holiness but also of His ineffable goodness, power, majesty and love. Their hope -